University of St.Gallen

Course and Examination Fact Sheet: Spring Semester 2026

8,394: Consultancy Project: Geopolitical Consulting

ECTS credits: 4

Overview examination/s

(binding regulations see below)
decentral - Presentation, Analog, Group work group grade (30%)
Examination time: Term time
decentral - Written work, Digital, Group work group grade (30%)
Examination time: Term time
decentral - Presentation, Analog, Group work group grade (20%)
Examination time: Term time
decentral - Written work, Digital, Individual work individual grade (20%)
Examination time: Term time

Attached courses

Timetable -- Language -- Lecturer
8,394,1.00 Consultancy Project: Geopolitical Consulting -- English -- Emmenegger Patrick , Blenk Timo Gerrit Alexander

Course information

Prerequisites

This course is open to all students with an interest in geopolitics on the one hand and corporate strategy on the other. Students should bring basic knowledge and understanding across the disciplines of International Affairs and have some experience working in diverse teams. It is recommended that students attend specific skills training, such as "Writing Policy Briefs" in the context of the "MIA Mornings" before taking this course. Students commit not to publish any results, documents, or other materials developed or used in the project.

Learning objectives

During this Consultancy Project course, students

- demonstrate the ability to evaluate and classify a problem and source a solution from its onset to its conclusion;
- assess the political, economic, social and intercultural environments to develop policy opportunities;
- hone their skills in mapping, analyzing, and assessing challenges and opportunities for the use of practitioners;
- foster creativity and various further skills, including teamwork, research, writing, and presentation.

Students who participate in this course will, afterwards, be able to

- better understand the contemporary geopolitical challenges and how they influence corporate strategies;
- choose and apply an appropriate method to analyze specific problem settings;
- translate academic findings to the corporate and policy world.

Content

Geopolitics refers to the ways in which geography, power, and international relations shape the behavior of states and other global actors. Traditionally, it has been concerned with questions of national security, territorial control, resource access, and the balance of power. In recent decades, however, the scope of geopolitics has widened. Economic interdependence, technological rivalry, access to critical minerals, climate change, and the increasing influence of non-state actors have made the global environment more complex and less predictable. As a result, geopolitics has become central to how firms operate and plan for the future.

Corporate strategy increasingly intersects with geopolitics because businesses are now deeply embedded in global supply chains, cross-border financial systems, and digital infrastructures shaped by competing national interests. Firms depend on stable rules, open markets, and secure access to resources—conditions that can be disrupted by geopolitical tensions. Trade wars, sanctions, industrial policy, data localization laws, and export controls have all become more common. For multinational corporations, decisions about where to invest, source inputs, locate production, or sell products now require assessing geopolitical risks alongside traditional market considerations.

Moreover, the boundaries between economic and security concerns have become blurred. Technologies such as semiconductors, artificial intelligence, biotechnology, and telecommunications equipment are treated as strategic assets by governments. This creates both constraints and opportunities for firms. Some companies find themselves caught between competing regulatory frameworks, while others benefit from state support or new markets created by geopolitical realignments. Understanding these dynamics is critical for anticipating how government actions can alter competitive landscapes.

The growing importance of geopolitics to corporate strategy is also driven by structural shifts in the global order. The rise of China, renewed great-power rivalry, the weaponization of interdependence, and regional conflicts all complicate the environment in which companies operate. Climate change and natural resource pressures add further layers of uncertainty. Crises—whether pandemics, wars, or financial shocks—now propagate more quickly through interconnected systems, amplifying risks for firms and supply chains.

Because the global environment is becoming more volatile and more politicized, companies need the ability to interpret geopolitical developments and integrate them into strategic decision-making. This requires not only awareness of current events but also conceptual tools for understanding how states pursue their interests, how power is exercised, and how global economic structures interact with political forces. Learning about geopolitics helps decision-makers think more systematically about risk exposure, resilience, and long-term positioning.

For students of international affairs, developing geopolitical literacy is increasingly essential. It equips future leaders with the analytical skills needed to navigate uncertainty, anticipate disruptions, and identify emerging opportunities. As firms become more intertwined with world politics, the ability to link geopolitical trends with corporate strategy is no longer optional—it is a core competence for operating in the 21st-century global economy. The aim of this Consultancy Project is to familiarize students with political risk analysis, strategic political advisory, and international crisis management. Participants in this course will be tasked with elaborating and presenting proposals to how companies can deal with geopolitical challenges, respond in international crisis situations, and manage related risks and challenges.

Structure and indications of the learning and teaching design

The course starts with a kick-off session held by the two course coordinators in St. Gallen in mid-February (first week of the spring term) during which students will be assigned to their respective groups and receive an introduction to political risk analysis, strategic political advisory, and international crisis management as well as their research task/consultancy cases. Students will work independently on their consultancy assignment in groups (allowed sizes to be determined at the kick-off meeting). In parallel, the course will meet in bi-weekly sessions (of four hours each) to continue the conservation on geopolitical analysis and corporate strategy. In these meetings, the course coordinators will introduce helpful tools and strategies for political risks analysis and international crisis management.

Moreover, experienced executives will join the class as guest lecturers and provide insights on real-world examples of international crisis management, sharing their perspectives on specific aspects of the course topic. Groups are expected to present their preliminary findings at the mid-term seminar, shortly after the spring break. In the final part of the course, groups will submit a final report in the form of a policy brief, and present their policy recommendations at the final meeting, which will be held on the premises of SwissRe in Zurich with members of the SwissRe Strategy Team attending the group presentations. After the presentation at SwissRe, students will be asked to reflect on their groups' individual journey, from defining the problem to coming up with a solution. This reflection paper will have to be submitted individually.

Literature

The lecturers / course coordinators will provide recommended literature (including academic articles, policy reports, media, etc.) on relevant topics throughout the duration of this course. The teams, in turn, are expected to search, review and analyze additional data and literature on their own.

Additional information

The course will be supervised by Timo Blenk and Patrick Emmenegger. Dr. Timo Blenk is CEO of the Agora Strategy Group, which is a geopolitical consulting firm specializing in political risk analysis, strategic political advisory, and international crisis management. For more information, please visit www.agora-strategy.com/en/. Patrick Emmenegger is Professor of Political Science with a special focus on Comparative Political Economy and Public Policy. For more information, please visit www.pemmenegger.com.

Examination information

Examination sub part/s

1. Examination sub part (1/4)

Examination modalities

Examination type	Presentation
Responsible for organisation	decentral
Examination form	Oral examination
Examination mode	Analog
Time of examination	Term time
Examination execution	Asynchronous
Examination location	On Campus
Grading type	Group work group grade
Weighting	30%
Duration	--

Languages

Question language: English
Answer language: English

Remark

Final presentation

Examination-aid rule

Free aids provision

Basically, students are free to choose aids. Any restrictions are defined by the faculty members in charge of the examination under supplementary aids.

Supplementary aids

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2. Examination sub part (2/4)

Examination modalities

Examination type	Written work
Responsible for organisation	decentral
Examination form	Written work
Examination mode	Digital
Time of examination	Term time
Examination execution	Asynchronous
Examination location	Off Campus
Grading type	Group work group grade
Weighting	30%
Duration	--

Languages

Question language: English
Answer language: English

Remark
Final report

Examination-aid rule
Free aids provision

Basically, students are free to choose aids. Any restrictions are defined by the faculty members in charge of the examination under supplementary aids.

Supplementary aids
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3. Examination sub part (3/4)

Examination modalities

Examination type	Presentation
Responsible for organisation	decentral
Examination form	Oral examination
Examination mode	Analog
Time of examination	Term time
Examination execution	Asynchronous
Examination location	On Campus
Grading type	Group work group grade
Weighting	20%
Duration	--

Languages
Question language: English
Answer language: English

Remark
Mid-term presentation

Examination-aid rule
Free aids provision

Basically, students are free to choose aids. Any restrictions are defined by the faculty members in charge of the examination under supplementary aids.

Supplementary aids
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4. Examination sub part (4/4)

Examination modalities

Examination type	Written work
Responsible for organisation	decentral
Examination form	Written work
Examination mode	Digital
Time of examination	Term time
Examination execution	Asynchronous
Examination location	Off Campus

Grading type	Individual work individual grade
Weighting	20%
Duration	--

Languages
Question language: English
Answer language: English

Remark
Reflection paper

Examination-aid rule
Free aids provision

Basically, students are free to choose aids. Any restrictions are defined by the faculty members in charge of the examination under supplementary aids.

Supplementary aids
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Content

Students are expected to participate fully in all aspects of the course including group work and presentations.

Midterm Presentation (20%, 15min.): Student groups present their approach in solving the problem, brief on their progress, including any roadblocks or difficulties that may have been encountered. All group members will be given the same grade.

Final Presentation (30%, 20 min.): Student groups present an in-depth analysis of the problem and their recommendations to the client. All group members will be given the same grade.

Final Report (30%, max. 5'000 words): Structured as a policy brief targeted at the client, reports typically give summaries of relevant research, suggest possible policy options, and propose particular courses of action. Next to an explanation of the problem and the results of the research undertaken, it outlines the methods used and the theories applied to analyze the problem. The brief might include graphs, charts, or other visual aids that make it easier to digest the most important information. All group members will be given the same grade.

Reflection Paper (20%, max. 1'000 words): Targeted at the academic lecturer, this paper invites students to reflect on their groups' individual journey, from defining the problem to coming up with a solution. It allows them to consider the challenge to apply what they have learned in a classroom setting to contemporary problems in a real-world setting. The reflection paper should be submitted individually and will be graded on an individual basis.

Literature

A reading list with recommended readings will be distributed at the kick-off session. Groups will identify additional literature relevant to the class, receive further input and data from the client and the course coordinator throughout the course, identify own data sources and collect relevant data (e.g., from expert interviews and publicly available databases).

Please note

Please note that only this fact sheet and the examination schedule published at the time of bidding are binding and takes precedence over other information, such as information on StudyNet (Canvas), on lecturers' websites and information in lectures etc.
Any references and links to third-party content within the fact sheet are only of a supplementary, informative nature and lie outside the area of responsibility of the University of St.Gallen.

Documents and materials are only relevant for central examinations if they are available by the end of the lecture period (CW21) at the latest. In the case of centrally organised mid-term examinations, the documents and materials up to CW 13 (Monday, 23rd March 2026) are relevant for testing.

Binding nature of the fact sheets:

- Course information as well as examination date (organised centrally/decentrally) and form of examination: from bidding start in CW 04 (Thursday, 22nd January 2026);
- Examination information (supplementary aids, examination contents, examination literature) for decentralised examinations: in CW 12 (Monday, 16 March 2026);
- Examination information (supplementary aids, examination contents, examination literature) for centrally organised mid-term examinations: in CW 14 (Monday, 30 March 2026);
- Examination information (regulations on aids, examination contents, examination literature) for centrally organised examinations: two weeks before ending with de-registration period in CW 15 (Monday, 06 April 2026).